



◀ Exotic foreigners

A tomb painting from Egypt's 18th Dynasty illustrates how Egyptians saw the Nubians. Here, a high status woman rides in a cart drawn by oxen. Unlike neighboring Egypt, Nubia gave women control in governance and the royal succession.



BIOGRAPHY

AMANIRENAS

Queen Amanirenas ruled from the battlefield as much as the throne. In 24 BCE, when Roman emperor Augustus tried to levy taxes on the Nubians, she led a 30,000-strong army to sack the Roman fort at Aswan, losing an eye in the ensuing battle. In response, she mutilated a statue of Augustus, burying its head at the threshold of the fort, so that all who came and went would tread upon it as a sign of disrespect. Even Greek writer Strabo said of her, "This Queen had a courage above her sex."

The public trust placed in African warrior queens is likely to have lifted the status of women in general. While there is far more evidence about the life of Nubia's ancient monarchs than about the condition of everyday women under their reign, there are indications that women across the social scale took an active role in public life. This included the right to own and sell property, and manage their own businesses. There are even instances of women, albeit with royal connections, rising to positions of administrative power as district governors. As household managers and food-producers, women not only undertook the labor, but also made key decisions about what to cultivate, where, and how. This level of control—over matters so pivotal to the

wellbeing of the entire community—supports the idea that even non-regal women enjoyed a degree of authority. This is substantiated by matrilineal naming customs, whereby children took their mothers' names rather than their fathers'.

Matriarchal structures decline

With so little evidence to draw on, it is vital not to overemphasize the position of women in these ancient African kingdoms, and pay too much attention to such exceptional examples as the ruling queens. Even so, it is clear that the matriarchal structures of ancient African societies were important. However, they did not last and were eroded gradually by external forces, largely in the forms of Christianity, Islam, and colonialism.